

Session 4 Pre-Work

Skills, MCPs, and the Collaborative Story

Instructor: Brady Allardice — brady.allardice@upf.edu

Session 4 introduces **MCPs** — the way Claude Code talks to systems outside your project. We will use two of them live: **GitHub** (for a collaborative writing exercise) and **Zotero** (for a citations demo). Both need to be installed and authenticated before class — they take 15–20 minutes each and the setup is too fiddly to do in the room.

Please complete **all six steps** below. Budget **45–60 minutes total**. If you get stuck for more than 10 minutes, stop and email me — don't try to debug it yourself. Once you are done, run the verification commands at the end and **send me a screenshot** of the output *and* your GitHub username (Step 2).

What You Need Before Starting

- Everything from the original Pre-Workshop Setup Guide working (Claude Code authenticated, VS Code running, Python installed)
- A GitHub account (created during initial setup)
- A free Zotero account — we'll create one in Step 5 if you don't have one

■ **If `claude -version` or `git -version` doesn't work, fix that first — these steps assume the original setup is intact.**

Step 1: Refresh the Course Repo

I have pushed new material into `session_4/`. Pull it down so you have it locally.

Open a terminal, navigate to wherever you cloned the course repo, and run:

```
git pull
```

You should see new files under `session_4/`. If `git pull` fails with a merge conflict, that is exactly the problem we fix in class — don't try to resolve it. Just email me and I will help you reset cleanly.

Step 2: Send Me Your GitHub Username

In Session 4 we run a **collaborative writing exercise** using a separate class GitHub repository. I need to add each of you as a collaborator before class so you can push branches and open pull requests.

Email me your GitHub username (not your email — the username, e.g. `octocat`) at brady.allardice@upf.edu. You can find it in the top-right of <https://github.com> after logging in.

■ If I don't have your username before Tuesday evening, you won't be able to participate in the exercise.

Step 3: Update Claude Code

The MCP install commands below assume Claude Code 2.1 or newer. Update to the latest version:

```
claude update
```

Then confirm the version:

```
claude --version
```

Expected: 2.1.x or higher.

Step 4: Install the GitHub MCP

The GitHub MCP lets Claude Code open pull requests, leave review comments, and create issues directly from the chat. We use it during the collaborative story exercise.

4a. Create a GitHub Personal Access Token

A Personal Access Token (PAT) is a password-like string that lets the MCP act on your behalf. **Treat it like a password** — don't paste it into chat, don't commit it to git.

- Go to <https://github.com/settings/tokens?type=beta>
- Click **Generate new token**
- **Token name:** claude-code-workshop
- **Expiration:** 90 days
- **Repository access:** "All repositories" is fine for the workshop
- **Repository permissions:** grant **Read and write** on *Contents*, *Issues*, and *Pull requests*
- Click **Generate token**, then **copy the token immediately** — GitHub will not show it again

Paste it into a temporary scratch file you will delete after Step 4b.

4b. Add the GitHub MCP to Claude Code

In your terminal, run (replace YOUR_PAT with the token you just copied):

```
claude mcp add --transport http github https://api.githubcopilot.com/mcp/ -H  
"Authorization: Bearer YOUR_PAT"
```

Then verify:

```
claude mcp list
```

You should see `github` in the list with a `Connected` status. **Now delete the scratch file containing your token.**

4c. Confirm it works

Open Claude Code in any directory and ask:

```
Use the GitHub MCP to list the five most recent public repos owned by my account.
```

If it returns a list, you are done. If it asks you to authenticate or returns an error, see Troubleshooting at the end.

Step 5: Install the Zotero MCP

The Zotero MCP lets Claude Code search your Zotero library, pull BibTeX, and insert citations into a draft. We use it for a citations demo and you will use it for your own papers afterward.

5a. Make sure you have a Zotero account with items in it

- If you don't have one, create a free account at <https://www.zotero.org/user/register>
- Install the **Zotero desktop app** from <https://www.zotero.org/download/> if you don't already have it — the MCP needs the desktop app running to read your local library (including full-text PDFs)
- Open the desktop app, sign in, and confirm you have **at least 5–10 items** in your library — if it's empty, the demo has nothing to search. Drag a few PDFs in or use the browser connector to grab a handful of papers

5b. Let Claude Code talk to your Zotero app

Zotero blocks other applications from connecting by default. Turn that off:

- Open the Zotero desktop app
- **Mac:** Zotero → Settings **Windows:** Edit → Settings
- Go to the **Advanced** tab
- Under **General**, check the box “**Allow other applications on this computer to communicate with Zotero**”
- Close the Settings window. **Leave Zotero running** — the MCP needs it open to query your library

■ **The MCP also falls back to the Zotero Web API if the desktop app is closed, but the local connection is faster and gives Claude Code access to your PDFs — worth turning on.**

5c. Get your Zotero API key and Library ID

- Go to <https://www.zotero.org/settings/keys>
- Your **Library ID** (a number, e.g. 1234567) is shown at the top under “Your userID for use in API calls”
- Click **Create new private key**
- **Key name:** claude-code-workshop

- Check **Allow library access** (read-only is fine; check write access too if you want Claude to add items)
- Click **Save Key**, then **copy the key immediately**

Save both the key and your Library ID into a temporary scratch file.

5d. Install the zotero-mcp package

Mac:

```
pip install zotero-mcp
```

If pip is not found, use:

```
pip3 install zotero-mcp
```

Windows:

```
py -m pip install zotero-mcp
```

Then confirm it installed:

```
zotero-mcp --help
```

Expected: a help message listing options. If you see “command not found,” close and reopen your terminal first.

5e. Add the Zotero MCP to Claude Code

Run (substituting your real values from Step 5c):

```
claude mcp add zotero -e ZOTERO_LIBRARY_ID=YOUR_LIBRARY_ID -e ZOTERO_API_KEY=YOUR_API_KEY  
-e ZOTERO_LIBRARY_TYPE=user - zotero-mcp
```

Then verify:

```
claude mcp list
```

You should now see both github and zotero listed with **Connected**. **Delete the scratch file with your key and Library ID.**

5f. Confirm it works

Open Claude Code in any directory and ask:

```
Use the Zotero MCP to list 5 items from my library.
```

If it returns a list of titles you recognize, you are done. **Make sure the Zotero desktop app is open** when you run this — if it isn’t, the MCP will either fail or fall back to the (slower) Web API.

Step 6: Re-Read the Session 3 Git Cycle (5 min)

Session 4 leans heavily on the Git workflow from Session 3. Spend five minutes re-reading the slides from Session 3 (`slides/session3_slides.pdf` in the course repo), specifically the `commit` → `instruct` → `diff` → `decide` cycle and how branches work. The collaborative story exercise will move faster than this if those concepts are fresh.

Verification: Confirm Everything Works

Open a terminal and run each of the following. **Take a screenshot of the full output and send it to me** along with your GitHub username from Step 2.

```
claude --version
```

Expected: 2.1.x or higher.

```
claude mcp list
```

Expected: both `github` and `zotero` listed with `Connected`.

```
zotero-mcp --help
```

Expected: a help message (any output is fine; “command not found” is the failure mode).

Also confirm:

- `git pull` on the course repo succeeds and you see a `session_4/` folder with new content
- Asking Claude Code “list 5 items from my Zotero library” returns titles
- Asking Claude Code “list my five most recent GitHub repos” returns repo names
- You have emailed me your GitHub username

Troubleshooting

claude mcp add fails with “unknown flag”: You are on an older Claude Code. Run `claude update` (Step 3) and try again.

GitHub MCP shows “Connected” but tool calls fail with 401/403: Your PAT is missing a permission. Regenerate it (Step 4a) and make sure *Contents*, *Issues*, and *Pull requests* are all set to *Read and write*. Then re-run the `claude mcp add` command — it will overwrite the existing entry.

Zotero MCP shows “Connected” but returns empty results: Your library is genuinely empty, or `ZOTERO_LIBRARY_TYPE` is wrong. If you set up a *group* library instead of a personal one, change `user` to `group` in the env var.

zotero-mcp: command not found after pip install: Close and reopen your terminal. If still failing, the install went to a directory not on your `PATH` — email me with the output of `pip show zotero-mcp` and I will help.

You accidentally pasted a token into a chat or committed it to git: Revoke it immediately (GitHub: <https://github.com/settings/tokens>; Zotero: <https://www.zotero.org/settings/keys>) and generate a new one. Tokens are easy to rotate; a leaked token in a public repo is not.

Anything else: Email me at brady.allardice@upf.edu. Do not spend more than 10 minutes troubleshooting on your own. I would much rather help you before the workshop than lose time during it.